# LYDIA JANSSEN

Lydia Janssen was born in Michigan, USA in 1976 and received a BA from Sarah Lawrence College, New York (1998). After graduating, she moved to New York City to pursue a professional dance career, dancing at the Merce Cunningham Studio School, and performing with Pam Tanowitz Dance Company and Jordana Toback/POON Dance Company.

Lydia's dance career ended after a knee injury, leading her to focus fully on her art. Lydia spent a year at the Graduate Fine Arts Department at the University of Massachusetts, Amherst, before returning to New York to study at the Art Students League of New York (2005-07), studying under Ronnie Landfield and Larry Poons. In Lydia's final year, she won the prestigious Red Dot Award for excellence in painting, chosen by the faculty. In 2020, Lydia's first monograph, 'Dance to Art', written by Ian Findlay-Brown, with a Foreword by Larry Poons, and published by SKIRA, was released, and launched at the Tate Modern (2021). After being selected into the 2021 London Art Biennale, Lydia won the Terme Award. Lydia's painting 'Spotlight Two' was acquired by the Chianciano Museum, Italy in 2022. Lydia was nominated for the 2023 Sovereign Asian Art Prize and the 2026 Portuguese Sovereign Art Prize.

Lydia's work has been exhibited at Melides Galeria, Portugal (2025), Cromwell Place, Peruke Projects, London, UK (2023), Chianciano Art Museum, Italy (2022), National Gallery Singapore Auction, Singapore (2022), London Art Biennale, UK (2021), COMO Ubud Bali, Indonesia, (2020), Susan Eley Fine Art Gallery (2019, 2014 Solo), REDSEA Gallery, Singapore (2018, 2023 Solo), The Asia Contemporary Art Fair, Hong Kong (2016) among others.

Many of Lydia's paintings are in private collections in the US, Europe and Asia, most notably in the collection of Singaporean collector Koh Seow Chuan and in the permanent collection of the Chianciano Museum, Italy.

Lydia lives between Bali, Indonesia and Portugal with her husband Luke and their three children.

*Foreword by Larry Poons for Lydia's first monograph, Dance to Art, published by Skira Editore 2020.*

Lydia Janssen is a painter I encountered more than a decade ago at the Art Students League in New York City. Her work had a particular appeal that made me take notice. She was clearly serious and committed to painting. Her intelligence and sincerity were apparent, and this was reflected in her approach to painting.

Realistically, I respond to a student's work as if it were my own and consider what I would do to it. It is more a suggestion than an instruction and it is up to the individual to interpret and utilize those ideas, to make them personal. As a painter who observes other painters (students), I can only hope the message gets through.

Some say that I am a difficult teacher, but being an artist isn't a walk in the park (and sometimes it is!). I remember shouting at her in class to stop looking and just paint. This is very important for students to learn from the get-go. An artist must paint without letting anything get in the way. Paint until you finish and then "wash your mouth out'' and start another.

As she began to bear down, Lydia's color sense changed. The application of color must be paramount. Lydia figured out how to use that notion and this differentiated her from other students.

Lydia took this to heart. She was challenged by the notion of ego and observation, of allowing 'mistakes' to play a part in her work, to make her art better. Now when I look at her paintings these notions still influence her work in an important way.

It is a pleasure to welcome this first monograph on Lydia's painting which will introduce many people to what I call a 'natural artist'. There are exciting turns of color throughout her output that point to an artist of original talent.

Larry Poons
New York, August 2019



*The Playfulness Of Discovery:*
*Interview with Ian Findlay Brown 2023*

*IFB: I have always seen a strong theatrical element at the centre of your art, which drives the tension of your narratives. But in recent works I sense that your art is more relaxed. Is this intentional or has it been realised just through the act of painting?*

LJ: I think the theatrical is still there, but while using the Wizard of Oz as reference, a childlike whimsy and perhaps even some surrealism is creeping in here. I also played with composition a lot in these works, leaning on my love of cave paintings and the seemingly random placement of symbols, and yes with that comes more relaxed gestures.

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*IFB: I never thought of the Wizard of Oz when looking at your work. But I did think of the playwright Sam Shepard (1943--2017) and your piece The Rocking Horse (2022). I see a touch of Surrealism and Portuguese colors and line, especially with horses in a number of your paintings. Your sense of connection to cave art is striking as is the intense energy of time and place.*

LJ: Yes, I can see how you would connect The Rocking Horse with Sam Shepard and the American West. I've always used symbols, some obvious some not, whether I pull them from cave paintings, or Native American themes, or images from my childhood home. Horses, guns, feathers, in a way I find that even in these relatively simple images, they can conjure up such lateral meanings, as seen in surrealism. I like that my viewers can play with that, discover or figure out the puzzle, perhaps that's where the playfulness comes from.

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*IFB: One of the most important artistic connections I see in your painting and drawing is that of the late Portuguese-British artist Paula Rego (1935--2022). The figurative narratives in both your oeuvres have a magical relationship to dream and reality. What is it that draws you to her art?*

LJ: There is just so much that draws me to Paula Rego and her work. Her Dogwomen series is one of the most powerful collections I've ever seen, as are her depictions of women in general, their strong, thick legs, tired, worn yet beautiful faces. Of course her use of lullabies resonates, how she confronts a difficult childhood through the use of these universal stories, in both a playful and macabre way.

I do think that her work is more intentional than mine, as she used props and still lifes, whereas mine is perhaps more stuck in the subconscious. But with both there lies magic and mystery for sure. And her technique is masterful to say the least, almost religious in its divinity. Her inks on paper are exquisite. She was also an expatriate, and a Mother to three as well.

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*IFB: What impact have your children had on your art?*

LJ: Being a mother to my three children has allowed reflection into my own childhood, an answering of questions, raising new questions and bringing out the child in me even. So, in a way, they have been teachers and guides allowing me to delve into my past and to be nostalgic. I do separate being an artist and being a mother, I find them to be opposites in some ways, selfish and selfless, they are two different characters within a play. All three are artists in their own way, the self-consciousness only now kicking in. They still paint without regard to ego or to any rules other than the ones they create. I long for that freedom, I am leaning towards the idea of painting this next series entirely with my non-dominant hand.

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*IFB: How did you decide on the title for the show?*

LJ: In a way, it was such an obvious choice, a phrase that resonates with so many people, a path, a trajectory, a crossroads: "Two roads diverged in a yellow wood, and sorry I could not travel both, I took the one less traveled on..." [from Robert Frost's poem "The Road Not Taken"] In all of our quests to find what is home, we often go back historically to our childhood, to those symbols and smells and people, and of course the film The Wizard of Oz, itself for me, reminds me of that time: the Yellow Brick Road being Dorothy's guide along the way.

*IFB: I find that the feeling of space and the relationship of objects in your recent paintings suggest a gentler tone to your art practice and a new opening up of your character with less anxiety. But how do you feel your art has changed over the past decade?*

LJ: I think that relaxation comes with experience, the knowledge that I know what I'm doing and can therefore play more within that framework. My work has changed a lot over this decade, introducing the use of faces, repetitive characters, and perhaps less abstract symbolism. I am excited to welcome in even more relaxed gestures, more complicated imagery, more drawings. I struggle with changing color palette though as I'm quite attached to the more subdued, natural tones I've been in for years now. Larry Poons used to make us cover the canvas entirely with our least favorite color and begin there. Maybe I'll bring that back.

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*IFB: As you look to the future do you have any plans for new works?*

LJ: I always have described the time away from the studio as passive work, but work nonetheless. It is when I forage and collect ideas, store them for the winter and release them when we're back in Bali. Again, I'm leaning towards even more space, more suggestions, more playfulness, exploring the surreal and painting even larger now that I have a larger studio space. The psychology of space is profoundly important as an artist, it can dictate so much of what is created.

Ian Findlay-Brown, 2023
Editor, Asian Art News



***Study in Release (Balloon),*** 2026

Oil and charcoal on linen

178 x 178 cm



***Study in Release (I),*** 2026
Oil and charcoal on linen
178 x 178 cm



***Untitled (Arms),*** 2026
Oil on linen
120 x 153 cm



***The Housebirds,*** 2025
Oil, charcoal and pastel on linen
178 x 256 cm



***The Hat-Trick (I),*** 2025

Oil and charcoal on linen

100 x 100 cm



***The Hat-Trick (II),*** 2025

Oil and charcoal on linen

100 x 100 cm



***The Mothership,*** 2024
Oil and charcoal on linen
178 x 178 cm



***The Roaring,*** 2024
Oil and charcoal on linen
178 x 178 cm




***Moving Mourning,*** 2024
Oil and charcoal on linen
178 x 178 cm



***The Mirage,*** 2024

Oil, charcoal and ink on linen

100 x 75 cm



***God, the Duck and the Devil,*** 2024

Oil and charcoal on linen

100 x 75cm



***Save our Souls,*** 2024

Oil and charcoal on linen

100 x 75 cm



***The Weight,*** 2024

Oil and pencil on linen

100 x 150 cm



***Yellow Couch,*** 2024

Oil, charcoal and pencil on linen

75 x 100 cm



***The Listing,*** 2023
Oil and charcoal on linen
120 x 152cm



***The Bed (on the ship),*** 2023

Oil and charcoal on linen

152 x 120 cm



***The Rocking Horse,*** 2022
Oil and charcoal on linen
200 x 330 cm



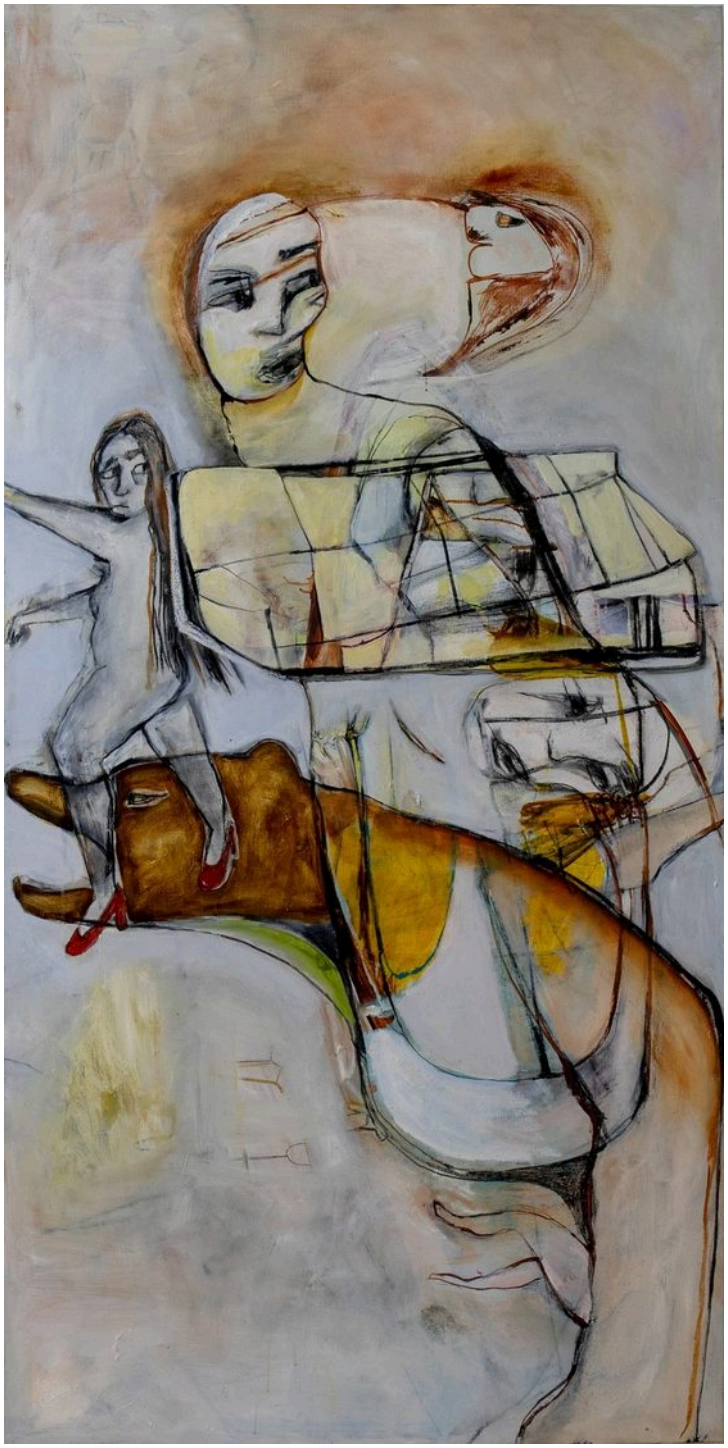
***The Slight Swimmer,*** 2022
Oil and charcoal on linen
75  x 96 cm



***The Talk,*** 2022

Oil, charcoal and ink on linen

75 x 99 cm



***The Misstep,*** 2022

Oil and charcoal on linen

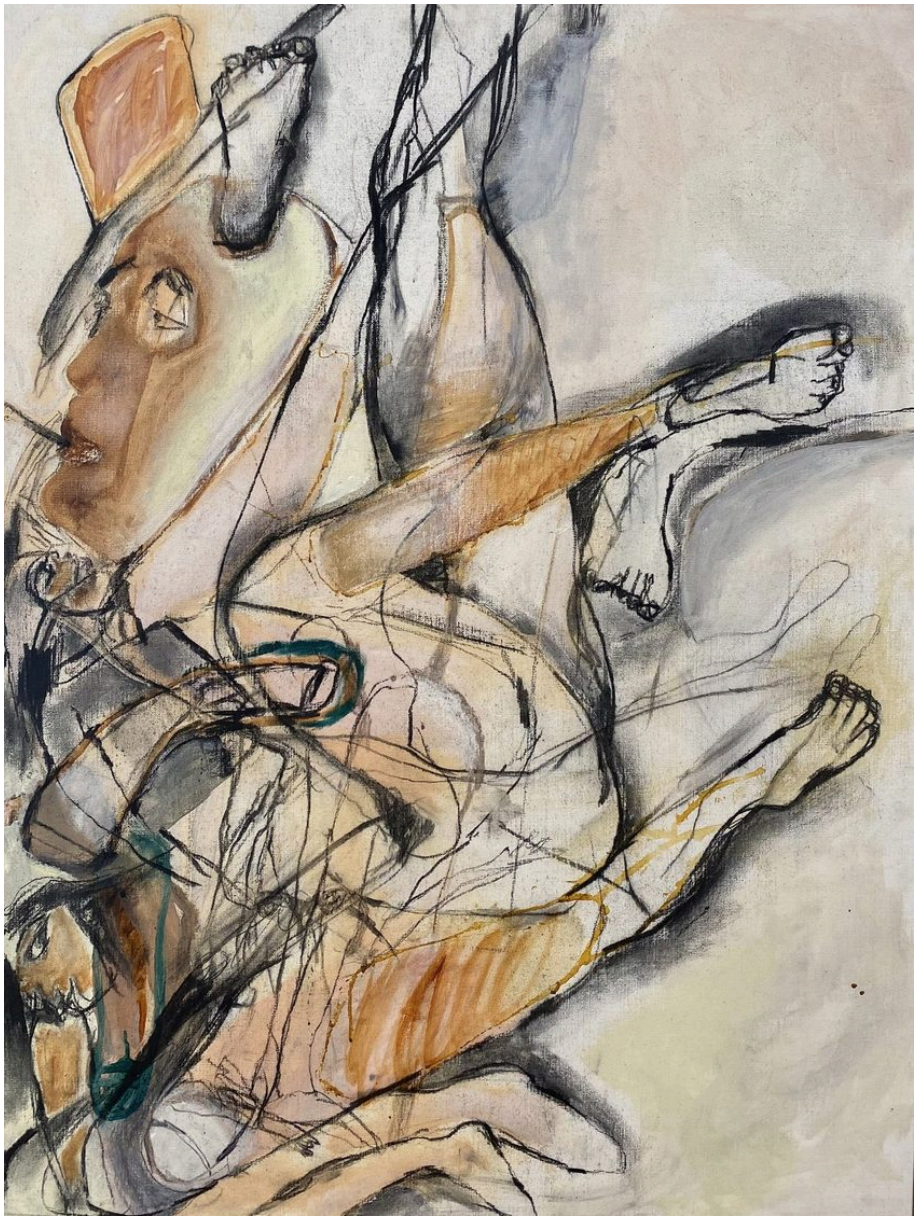
200 x 100 cm



***The Party,*** 2020

Oil and charcoal on linen

100 x 300 cm



***Spotlight One,*** 2019

Oil and charcoal on linen

99 x 76 cm



***Spotlight Three,*** 2019

Oil and charcoal on linen

76 x 99 cm



***Orange Grove,*** 2017

Oil, chalk, pastel and charcoal on linen

100 x 200 cm

# CV

**EDUCATION**
The Art Students League of New York, New York, NY (2005–2007)
University of Massachusetts, Graduate Fine Arts Department, Amherst, MA (2004–05)
Sarah Lawrence College, Bronxville, NY, Bachelor of Arts (1994–98)
Walnut Hill School for the Arts, Natick, MA (1991–1994)

**AWARDS**
Portuguese Sovereign Art Prize, Nominated (2026)
Sovereign Asian Art Prize, Nominated (2023)
Terme Award Winner, London Art Biennale, London, England (2021)
Red Dot Award for Excellence in Painting, The Art Students League of New York (2006)

**COLLECTIONS**
Private collections throughout the US, Europe and Asia, most notably in the collection of Singaporean collector Koh Seow Chuan, and the permanent collection of the Chianciano Art Museum, Italy.

**RESIDENCIES**
Arteles, Finland (2026)
Àrea de Creació i Art (ACA), Mallorca, Spain (2018)

**REPRESENTATION**
REDSEA Gallery, Singapore

**PUBLICATIONS**
Dance to Art, written by Ian Findlay-Brown, foreword by Larry Poons, published by SKIRA (2020)

# EXHIBITIONS

*The Landing*, 101 Gallery/Trinity School, New York, NY (2026) — Solo
*Ressonância*, group show with Jason Martin, curated by Grace Kasep, Melides Galeria, Melides, Portugal (2025)
*Itinerant Projects*, Peruke Projects, Cromwell Place, London, UK (2023)
*Yellow Brick Road*, REDSEA Gallery, Singapore (2023) — Solo
Chianciano Art Museum, Group Show, Italy (2022)
National Gallery Singapore, Art Auction, Singapore (2022)
London Art Biennale, London, England (2021) — *Winner of the Terme Award*
*Asian Art News* cover, interview and editorial (2018, 2021)
*Dance to Art* Book Launch, Tate Modern, London, England (2021)
*Spotlight*, COMO Ubud, Ubud, Bali, Indonesia (2020) — Solo
*Winter Selects*, group show, Susan Eley Gallery, New York, NY (2019)
*All the King's Horses*, REDSEA Gallery, Singapore (2018) — Solo
Singapore Contemporary Art Fair, Singapore (2017)
Asia Contemporary Art Fair, Hong Kong (2016)
Singapore Contemporary Art Fair, Singapore (2015)
*Fusion*, Art Equity, group show, The American Club, Singapore (2015)
Art SiliconValley/SanFrancisco, group show, Susan Eley Gallery, CA (2015)
*Course Change*, Susan Eley Gallery, New York (2014) — Solo
Selected for the HBO series *Too Big To Fail (*2010)
Trumans, Selected group show, New York, New York (2009)
*Manin*, Selected group show, Cielo, New York, New York (2008)
Poon Productions, Mural Commission, New York, New York (2007)
*The Pathos of Ecstasy*, group show, Muhlenberg College, PA (2007)
*Tower 49*, Selected group show, New York, NY (2007)
Group Show, The Art Students League Gallery, New York, NY (2006) — *Red Dot Award Winner*
*Recent Paintings*, Nacul Center, Amherst, MA (2005) — Solo
*Studio 14*, Asian Fusion Gallery, New York, NY (2005)
*Take Home a Nude*, New York Academy of Art, New York, NY (2000)
*Take Home a Nude*, New York Academy of Art, New York, NY (1999)
A*Space Gallery, Bronxville, NY (1998)
The L Café Gallery, Brooklyn, NY (1998) — Solo

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